

When talking about what separates the best from the rest on the pro tour, former No. 1 Jim Courier said, “It all comes down to the big moments. Do you play your best when the pressure is greatest? You need to at this level.”

All too often in his chequered career, Alexander Zverev failed the Courier test. To his great credit, though, he shed the dreaded ‘greatest player never to win a Grand Slam’ label when he captured the French Open in June. Zverev lucked out with an extremely easy draw, facing only one top-25-ranked opponent, No. 14 Cobolli, and needed five sets to overcome him in the final.

In the Wimbledon final against Sinner, huge-serving Sascha blasted his once-suspect forehand with abandon for nearly two sets before going strangely passive. The predictable result: the relentlessly aggressive Italian capitalised and prevailed 6-7(7), 7-6(2), 6-3, 6-4. At Cincinnati, Zverev regressed again in the big moment. Rallying instead of attacking on match point against Tommy Paul, he squandered his big chance and eventually lost 4-6, 7-6(6), 6-4.

That timidity won’t cut it in the 29-year-old German’s bid to win his second Major title.

ALEXANDER ZVEREV

No. 3



Prediction: Finalist

“Vamos!” Oh, how sports aficionados have missed the battle cry of the most charismatic champion of this decade, this century, and maybe ever.

Questions abound about the return of Carlitos. How rusty will he be after the longest layoff of his young pro career? Which parts of his game might

suffer most from competitive inactivity? Will his wrist hold up against the ferocious power and long rallies he’ll certainly encounter? Will his high-energy game prove even more dynamic after the long rest? Will the supremely versatile superstar surprise us with technique tweaks or tactical changes? Will the roar of

the crowd — and there will be many roars — fuel him? Will the absence of archrival Sinner affect him?

An easy draw in the first two rounds would certainly help Alcaraz get back into the tournament groove. On the other hand, he might prefer a tough opponent or two to test his multifaceted game better.

“HERE WE GO” — wrote Carlitos on *Instagram* to announce his eagerly awaited return. The defending champion is back in quest for his third US Open and eighth Grand Slam title. Once again, Alcaraz will show why he’s the best tennis player and the best athlete in the world.

Prediction: Champion

CARLOS ALCARAZ

No. 2

